

# Real Cron Job Scenario Questions – Ubuntu (Questions in Blue)

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## 1. Where are cron logs stored in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

Cron logs are stored in:

`/var/log/syslog`

Check logs:

`grep CRON /var/log/syslog`

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## 2. How do you schedule a cron job to run every 5 minutes in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

`*/5 * * * * /home/ubuntu/scripts/monitor.sh`

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## 3. How do you open and edit the crontab in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

Edit: `crontab -e`

View: `crontab -l`

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## 4. How do you set environment variables inside cron in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

Cron ignores `~/ .bashrc`, so set variables at the top:

`PATH=/usr/local/sbin:/usr/local/bin:/usr/sbin:/usr/bin:/sbin:/bin`

`ENV=prod`

`0 * * * * /home/ubuntu/app/deploy.sh`

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## 5. Cron job to restart a service if it stops running (Ubuntu-specific)

**Answer:**

`*/3 * * * * systemctl is-active --quiet nginx || systemctl restart nginx`

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## 6. How do you run a script at startup using cron (Ubuntu)?

**Answer:**

`@reboot /home/ubuntu/scripts/startup.sh`

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## 7. How do you run a cron job daily at 1:30 AM?

**Answer:**

```
30 1 * * * /home/ubuntu/db/backup.sh
```

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## 8. Script runs manually but not via cron — Ubuntu-specific causes?

**Answer:**

Common issues:

- Missing PATH (cron uses /usr/bin:/bin)
  - Missing shebang: #!/bin/bash
  - Permission issue: `chmod +x script.sh`
  - Relative paths used → cron needs absolute paths
  - Missing environment variables
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## 9. Cron job to clean logs older than 7 days?

**Answer:**

```
0 0 * * * find /var/log/myapp/ -type f -mtime +7 -delete
```

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## 10. How to test if cron is running in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

```
systemctl status cron
sudo systemctl enable cron
sudo systemctl start cron
grep CRON /var/log/syslog
```

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## 11. Run a cron job every 15 minutes between 9 AM – 6 PM?

**Answer:**

```
*/15 9-18 * * * /home/ubuntu/scripts/health_check.sh
```

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## 12. Disable cron email notifications in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

```
*/5 * * * * /home/ubuntu/ping.sh > /dev/null 2>&1
```

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### 13. Run a cron job on the first day of every month at midnight?

**Answer:**

```
0 0 1 * * /home/ubuntu/monthly_cleanup.sh
```

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### 14. Run a cron job as root instead of ubuntu user?

**Answer:**

For root: `sudo crontab -e`

For ubuntu: `crontab -e`

Difference: root can run privileged commands.

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### 15. Cron job needs Python 3 but cron uses Python 2 — fix?

**Answer:**

```
*/10 * * * * /usr/bin/python3 /home/ubuntu/scripts/cleanup.py
```

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### 16. Run cron job at 3 AM and 3 PM daily?

**Answer:**

```
0 3,15 * * * /home/ubuntu/scripts/report.sh
```

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### 17. Prevent multiple cron instances from running (lock file)?

**Answer:**

```
* * * * * /usr/bin/flock -n /tmp/cleanup.lock  
/home/ubuntu/cleanup.sh
```

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### 18. Run cron job only on weekdays (Mon–Fri)?

**Answer:**

```
0 9 * * 1-5 /home/ubuntu/scripts/daily_standup_reminder.sh
```

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### 19. Cron job fails because AWS credentials not loaded — why?

**Answer:**

Cron does not load `~/.aws/credentials`.

Fix 1:

```
AWS_ACCESS_KEY_ID=xxxx  
AWS_SECRET_ACCESS_KEY=xxxx  
0 * * * * /home/ubuntu/s3_sync.sh
```

Fix 2:

```
export AWS_SHARED_CREDENTIALS_FILE=/home/ubuntu/.aws/credentials
```

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## 20. Ensure cron uses correct timezone in Ubuntu?

**Answer:**

```
timedatectl  
sudo timedatectl set-timezone Asia/Kolkata
```

Cron automatically uses the system timezone.